SYNTAXE DES LANGUES INDO-IRANIENNES ANCIENNES

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ON THE EXPRESSION OF REFLEXIVE POSSESSION IN THE RIG-VEDA: RV *SVÁ-*

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1. *Introductory*

1.1 As in so many other cases, the features and problems associated with the Sanskrit so-called reflexive pronoun (or adjective) *svá-* were given a masterful and insightful discussion by Delbrück, in his handbook survey published a century ago.[1] Among subsequent discussions of the behavior of *svá-* (or of the expression of reflexive possession more generally) that go beyond Delbrück's treatment, the most important, despite its brevity, is that of C. Watkins,[2] prompted in its turn by a discussion of W. Lehmann.[3] The present preliminary reanalysis of *svá-* in the Rig-Veda will therefore address various details of these treatments, and especially those of Delbrück and Watkins.

For convenience and orientation, consider first the following representative description of *svá-* and some of its salient properties, drawn from the handbook accounts by Renou:

(1) a. *Gramm. véd.* § 282: "Il n'y a de proprement "personnel", pour la 3e personne, que *svá-* ..., qui d'ailleurs fonctionne aussi pour les 1re et 2e pers. et est en fait un adjectif possessif à valeur réfléchie 399."

b. op. cit. § 399: "*Svá-* fonctionne comme adjectif réfléchi 282 (très rares attestations comme substantif, ainsi en rôle de sujet II 5 7); la nuance est souvent insistante, voire emphatique. Le substantif accompagnant peut supporter un G. possessif, *dāśúṣaḥ své sadhásthe* III 51 9 'dans le propre séjour de l'adorateur'".

Cf. *Gramm. sanscr.* § 255: "*sva-* ... insiste en principe sur la notion de propriété". *Svá-* is described as a possessive adjective[4] with so-called "reflexive" value that may refer to all three persons; it rarely occurs as a subject; it may have an accompanying genitive, as in the example in (1b); and it often has a so-called "emphatic" value that underlines the notion of ownership-hence Renou's standard translation, throughout *EVP,* via "propre" for most cases, and Geldner's almost automatic rendering with "eigen".

1.2 For reasons that should become clear later, it will be more convenient to return to these issues after first considering in some detail another well-known property of *svá-,* namely the fact that the possessor indicated with *svá-* need not correspond with the grammatical

1. B. Delbrück, *Vergl. Synt.* I (= *Grdr.* III), 477-98, esp. 486ff. ("**svo*").
2. C. Watkins, in *Toward PIE Syntax.*
3. W. Lehmann, *PIE Syntax* 128f. and passim.
4. On the marginally pronominal morphology of Ved. *svá-* see Banti, *Morphol.* 42, 45.

subject. The following formulation by Renou is traditional (it is essentially that of Delbrück): "Le sens réfléchi est à entendre logiquement plutôt que grammaticalement; c'est-à-dire que *ātman- sva-* se rapportent à l'agent principal du procès, même si le nom figure de façon accessoire ou oblique dans la phrase" (*Gramm. sanscr.* ibid.). Such a formulation operates, however, with notoriously vague constructs like "logical subject" and "principal agent", which in practice fail to account for many instances. Consider, for example, the following:

(2) 1.119.8ab *ágachataṃ kṛ́pamāṇaṃ parāváti*
pitúḥ ***svásya*** *tyájasā níbādhitam*
"They [i.e. the Aśvins] approached the one wailing in the distance [i.e. Bhujyu], (who had been) driven down as a result of his own father's rejection."

Here, the reflexive possessive refers neither to the grammatical subject, nor to what could reasonably be called a logical subject; it refers, in fact, to what might now be called an "experiencer", and not to any agent at all. An important advance, with regard to such problems, was made by Watkins, in the study referred to above. According to Watkins, those cases in which *svá-* does not refer to the grammatical subject could be described in terms of their discourse properties, specifically in terms of the notion "topic".[5] Watkins cites the following example (here presented as it appears in his discussion):

(3) RV 6.17.5: *mahắm ádrim ... nutthắ ... sádasas pári svắt*
"great stone you-pushed from 'own' place"

The stone in question is grammatically the direct object, but appears in thematic position, clearly qualifying as a topic; hence the reference in the phrase "from its place". As it happens, I will suggest below that this particular example is to be interpreted somewhat differently, and that the notion "topic" is in itself insufficient to account for some cases: for the present, note that the possessor in example (2) above is not in fact the "topic", but rather the "focus", which thus appears to occupy the status of a rheme, and not a theme (to use the familiar Praguean terminology). Nevertheless, I hope to provide evidence demonstrating that Watkins' insight is fundamentally correct; and in any case, there are at least a few indisputable instances in which "pure" topic control of the reflexive possessive expression does seem to be involved. In the spirit of much recent work in which principles of discourse analysis have been fruitfully brought to bear on the peculiar expressive diction of the Rig-Veda,[6] it may be worthwhile to examine briefly several such cases of "pure" topic control involving *svá-*.

2. *"Pure" topic control*

Consider the examples in (4):

5. "**su̯-* refers back to the topic of the sentence, not to the subject, where the two do not coincide".
6. Cf. the reference in § 4.4 below to Hale's analysis of RV *eṣá-/etá-*.

(4) a. 1.143.4cd *agníṃ táṃ gīrbhír hinuhi **svá** á dáme / yá éko ...*
"That Agni rouse with praise-songs in his own house, who alone ..."

b. 3.42.8ab *túbhyéd indra **svá** okyè / sómaṃ codāmi pītáye*
"*You*, O Indra, I incite to drink the soma in your own dwelling."

In both (4a) and (4b), the pāda-initial items appear in oblique cases, and clearly represent topical elements; this is especially clear in (4b), in which the initial pronoun is reinforced by a postpositive particle, and then by the immediately following vocative. Some other cases, however, are more complex, generally because of ellipses and/or brachylogies. A more careful consideration of the discourse behavior of *svá-*, in the terms expressed by Watkins, may help clarify (or at least justify) the interpretation of some such passages. Thus, in the passage in (5), the topic/comment structure of pādas c and d cannot be considered apart from the first two pādas, which establish Uśanas Kāvya as the recipient of Indra's benefaction:

(5) 6.20.11
a *tváṃ vṛdhá indra pūrvyó bhūr*
b *varivasyánn uśáne kāvyáya*
c *párā návavāstvam anudéyaṃ*
d *mahé pitré dadātha **svám** nápātam*
"You, Indra, were the first increaser, when you sought a remedy for Uśanas Kāvya; (to him) (you gave) back Navāvastva, the restored (?) one - to the grandfather you restored his own grandson."

The interpretation of pāda c indicated in the above translation, which follows Geldner, assumes that "Uśanas Kāvya" continues to be topical (although with brachylogy), joined with the new rhematic element "Navavāstva", and that these two items are then reinforced in pāda d with the parallel and pointedly contrasting kinship terms.

3. *Reanalysis of other alleged cases with topic control*

3.1 What is to be said, then, about cases like (2) (repeated directly below for convenience), where, as already noted, a simple description in terms of "topic" control of the referent of the reflexive possessive does not appear to work, at least at first glance:

(2) 1.119.8ab *ágachataṃ **kṛ́pamāṇaṃ** parāváti*
*pitúḥ **svásya** tyájasā **níbādhitam***
"They [i.e. the Aśvins] approached the one wailing in the distance [i.e. Bhujyu], (who had been) driven down as a result of his own father's rejection."

I suggest that in such cases, the behavior of *svá-* can be circumscribed in a potentially interesting way: if we make the assumption that the participle *níbādhitam* stands, at some syntactic level, for a so-called reduced relative clause, then the reflexive possessive in such

a case is entirely natural- it not only refers to the "topic" of its underlying clause, but actually to its subject, so that in this sense there is actual coreference with an underlying subject. Note further that in this particular instance, the oblique-case participle that controls the reflexive expression (*nībādhitam*) is preceded by another participle in apposition (*kṛ́pamāṇam*). If, as seems likely, this first participle has a definite (rather than an indefinite) interpretation (i.e., "the one who was wailing", and not "someone [who was] wailing"), the thematic status of the second participle ("the one who had been driven down") would thereby be reinforced.

To be sure, the nature of the distinctions between full and reduced expressions remains a matter of debate, despite evident similarities between full relative clauses and various other reduced forms, especially attributive adjectives and participial constructions. Nor, to my knowledge, has the problem been addressed in any detail on the basis of Vedic material.[7] There seems, however, little difficulty in assuming at least some form of syntactic equivalence between full and reduced relative constructions in Vedic, as would be suggested in any case by passages like those in (6), where the full relative clause in pāda b is continued by parallel adjectival and participial constructions in pādas c and d:

(6) 7.12.1
a *áganma mahā́ námasā yáviṣṭhaṃ*
b ***yó*** *dīdā́ya sámiddhaḥ* ***své*** *duroṇé*
c ***citrábhānuṃ*** ...
d ***svà́hutaṃ*** ...
"We went with great reverence to (Agni,) the youngest one, who shines, when kindled, in his own abode - the one gleaming with light ..., well-sprinkled ..."

3.2 As for *svá-* itself, it emerges that by far the majority of instances that, according to Watkins' formulation, would need to be described as "topic"-controlled, with oblique-case referents for the possessive, in fact involve participial constructions, as shown in (7):

(7) a. [pres. ptcple.]
1.1.8c ***várdhamānaṃ*** ***své*** *dáme*
2.2.4a ***ukṣámāṇam*** ... ***svá*** *á dáme*
10.183.2b ***svā́yāṃ*** *tanū́* ***nā́dhamānām***

b. [perf. ptcple.]
2.2.11d ***dīdivā́ṅsaṃ*** ***své*** *dáme*
4.2.8cd ***své*** *dáma* ... *tám* ... ***dāsvā́ṅsam***

c. [*-*to*- ptcple.]
1.119.8b *pitúḥ* ***svásya*** *tyájasā* ***nībādhitam*** [(2) above]
3.1.14c ***vṛddhā́ṃ*** *sádasi* ***své***

7. For a brief discussion of the problem of reduced relative constructions in Vedic, see H. Hettrich, *Hypotaxe* 514f. (with several more general references); note also Lehmann, *op. cit.* 37f. (after Wackernagel), analyzing participial clauses in terms of reduced relative clauses.

6.17.9b ***ácyutaṃ*** *sádasas pári* ***svā́t*** [(3) above, (8) below]
d. [adj.] 8.84.8c ***svéṣu*** *kṣáyeṣu* ***vājínam***

Indeed, in view of the systematic nature of this behavior, it may not be excessive to suggest that further progress in exploring the question of reduced relative expressions in Vedic could well be expected to come from facts like these, in which the participial expressions fall into a discrete and linguistically definable subclass.

3.3 There may also be some interpretive (as opposed to theoretical) consequences attending this conception of the behavior of *svá-* in terms of reduced relative constructions. The most interesting seems to me to involve the example cited in (3) above in connection with Watkins' original observation concerning "topic" control, and repeated in (7c) among examples with **to*-participles. Consider now the full text of pādas c and d of this stanza, together with Geldner's translation:

(8) 6.17.5cd *mahā́m ádrim pári gā́ indra sántaṃ*
nutthā́ ***ácyutaṃ*** *sádasas pári* ***svā́t***
"Den großen Fels, der die Kühe gefangen hielt, hast du von seinem Platz gestoßen, den unbeweglichen, o Indra."

This translation is apparently standard: similarly Delbrück (*op. cit.* 494) "stiessest du ... von seinem eigenen ... Sitze". The only salient difference between Geldner's version and that of Delbrück is that Delbrück, who cites both pādas in full, nevertheless leaves the participial form *ácyutam* entirely untranslated. But in view of the evidence presented above, I would suggest that the ablative phrase (*sádasas pári svā́t*) depends directly on *ácyutam,* in a reduced-relative interpretation, and not on the verb *nutthā́* (cf. also the word order itself); this would yield, rather, a translation along the lines of: "You pushed (away) the great stone ..., which could not be moved from its place".[8] It is also suggestive that in the Rig-Veda, *nud-* itself, which occurs some twenty-five times, generally occurs alone, or with a simple direct object (23x), and never appears with ablative or ablative phrase, even when it clearly means "push away".[9] A final observation concerning this example is based on another point about *svá-* raised by Watkins, recalling Delbrück's conception according to which the antecedent of *svá-* must be animate and personal, so that the stone, in this case, represents a personification.[10] It seems to me, however, that the personification as such is somewhat easier to account for via *ácyuta-,* which by virtue of its meaning would naturally refer to beings or elements conceived of as potentially animate, and which is otherwise attested with

8. Cf. the similar usage of *ácyutam* at RV 6.15.1d, but in a full relative clause (... *yád ácyutam* "that which is fixed").

9. Apart from "absolute" usages (with or without direct object): only 7.18.16b *nunude abhí kṣā́m,* 1.85.11a *nunudre ... táyā diśā́.*

10. "...*svá* darauf deutet, dass der 'Fels' als eine Art von Dämon gedacht ist. Denn im Veda bezieht sich *svá* wohl nur auf Personen." (Delbrück, *op. cit.* 494n1).

animates (e.g. Indra, *vā́ta-*), or (as most commonly) a kind of pseudo-animate like the atmospheric term *rájas-*; this latter collocation (cf. also *nud-* + *vā́ta-*) would seem to be of interest in connection with the standard view[11] that *adri-* here and elsewhere refers to stationary clouds.

4. *svá-* + *genitive*

4.1 We are now in a position to address the remaining cases in which *svá-* appears to refer to someone other than the grammatical subject, the most frequent type represented by examples like that in (9) directly below, which is repeated, in fuller form, from (1b) above:

(9) 3.51.9cd [cf. (1b)] *tébhiḥ sākáṃ píbatu vṛtrakhādáḥ*
sutáṃ sómaṃ ***dāśúṣaḥ své sadhásthe***
"Together with them [i.e. the Maruts] shall the Vṛtra-destroyer drink the pressed soma in the worshipper's own dwelling."[12]

The failure of *svá-* to refer to the grammatical subject is precisely one of the defining characteristics of this interesting construction, which actually provides a key to the understanding of the syntax and semantics of *svá-*, despite the fact that this usage is rarely discussed, except, so to speak, parenthetically, as in (1b) above. Once again, the essential point of this usage was seen already by Delbrück; it remains only to reinterpret his statements in more precise terms, and to draw certain conclusions to which they lead. Consider now Delbrück's treatment, where the last sentence indicates his syntactic interpretation:

(10) "... ich in den arischen Sprachen ein substantivisches Reflexivpronomen nicht gefunden habe, wohl aber in allen indogermanischen Sprachen ein adjektivisches mit der Bedeutung 'eigen'. Nicht selten kann bei diesem Adjektivum die Person, der etwas eigen ist, im Genitiv stehen, z. B. *devásya své kṣáye* im eigenen Sitze des Gottes RV. 8, 2, 7. Da aber das Substantivum, zu dem **svo* gehört, als die Hauptperson des Satzes bekannt ist, so bleibt es in der Mehrzahl der Fälle weg." (Delbrück, *op. cit.* 497)

The purpose of this construction, in pragmatic terms, is therefore to introduce a new rhematic item, as is clear, for example, from (9). Here the possessive phrase refers not to the topical Maruts, nor to the grammatical subject Indra, nor (if it were personified) to soma, but to the entirely new person introduced via *dāśúṣaḥ*, much as in comparable genitive phrases without *svá-*, as in, say, (11):

(11) 3.25.4ab *ágna índraś ca* ***dāśúṣo duroṇé***
sutávato yajñám ihópa yātam

11. E.g. Macdonell, *Ved. Mythol.* 10, 60; similarly Gonda *Indra Hymns* 124.
12. *svá-* + gen. with non-subject: also 1.139.2g, 3.7.6d, 5.64.5c, 8.2.7c, etc. (ca. 10x).

"Agni and Indra, come hither in the house of the worshipper, to the offering of the soma-presser."

Indeed, Delbrück has himself misinterpreted his own example, the full text of which runs as in (12):

(12) 8.2.7 [cf. (10)] *tráya índrasya sómāḥ*
sutā́saḥ santu devásya
své kṣáye sutapā́vnaḥ
"Let the three somas be pressed of [i.e. for] the god Indra, in the soma-drinker's own house."

The genitive *devásya* clearly belongs with Indra, whereas the "new" genitive *sutapā́vnaḥ* with *své kṣáye* refers to a new rhematic person, who is precisely not Indra (cf. Sāyaṇa's comment ad loc. that this pāda refers to the house in which the offering is made).

4.2 In some cases, the genitive marks not a completely new element, but a *return* to a previously-named topic which has been displaced by another; not unnaturally, the genitive in such a case may be pronominal, as in (13):

(13) 7.56.24 *asmé vīró marutaḥ śuṣmy àstu*
jánānāṃ yó ásuro vidhartā́
apó yéna sukṣitáye tárema
*ádha **svā́m óko** abhí **vaḥ** syāma*
pāda d: "Und wir möchten euch mehr gelten als das eigene Heim." (Geldner)[13]
"Puissions nous alors accéder à votre propre résidence!" (Renou)[14]

Insofar as this is a hymn to the Maruts, the Maruts constitute the so-called "hypertheme", which makes an explicit appearance, in this penultimate stanza of the hymn, in the vocative of pāda a.[15] There is, however, a surfeit of other referents introduced in the first three pādas, namely the first-person plural pronominal of *asmé,* the heroic figure *vīrá-,* and the waters in pāda c. If, as seems likely to me, Renou's conception of *abhí as-* is correct, the most natural interpretation of the enclitic pronoun *vaḥ* in pāda d is as a genitive, in a *svá-* + genitive construction, marking a return to the Maruts, who last appeared in the initial vocative.

In two cases (both in the same collection [Bharadvāja, Agni-hymns]), a pronominal genitive *táva* in a *svá-* + genitive construction seems to be "pleonastic", or perhaps serves

13. Cf. Geldner *ad loc.*: "Nach Sāy.: 'wir wollen als die Euren zum eignen Wohnort gelangen.' Darnach auch möglich: 'Wir möchten (mit) eurer (Hilfe) zu eigenem Heim gelangen.'"

14. Cf. *EVP* ad loc. (X [1962], p. 102) on *abhí as-* 'atteindre, accéder à'.

15. On the concept of hypertheme, see Daneš, *FSP* 109.

to emphasize the second-person reference already expressed in accompanying second-person imperatives: *tám ajárebhir vṛ́ṣabhis táva svaís / tápā* ... "burn him with your own ageless bull-like (flames)" (6.5.4cd, lit. "with the own ... of you"), *ágne yájasva tanvàṃ táva svám* "O Agni, offer your own self!" (6.11.2d, lit. "the own body/self of you") - thus perhaps "(with) your own actual ... ", vel sim. Different, but somewhat complex, is the opening of the famous funeral hymn 10.18 (also adduced by Watkins), in which an enclitic *te* (almost certainly to be interpreted as genitive, in a *svá-* + genitive construction) appears in a relative clause: *páraṃ mṛ́tyo ánu párehi pánthāṃ / yás te svá ítaro devayánāt* "Go forth, death, along the path which is your own, different from that of the gods" (10.18.1ab, lit. "(path) which is the own of you"). Here the new subject *yás,* referring to the newly-introduced rhematic "path", calls for the genitive pronoun *te,* as a way of referring back to the initial topic "death", very much as in (13) above.

4.3 Two further points can be made with regard to *svá-* + genitive. First, I suggest that the regular behavior of *svá-* + genitive as just described may help interpret an otherwise problematic passage with *svá-* containing a similar construction, namely 10.120.9ab:

(14) 10.120.9ab *evá́ mahán bṛ́háddivo átharvā*
*ávocat **svā́ṃ tanvàm índram evá***
"Also hat der große Bṛhaddiva Atharvan zu ihm selbst, zu Indra gesprochen:" (Geldner, contra Bergaigne *Relig. véd.* 1.46, cf. Geldner's fn. 3 ad loc.: "wörtlich...: 'zu seinem Leibe, eben (*evá*) zu Indra")

Bergaigne's idea was that Bṛhaddiva had somehow by this point (i.e. the last stanza of the hymn) reached a state wherein he is expressing an identification of himself with Indra. But Geldner is surely correct in taking this otherwise, i.e. as an address directed "ad Indrum ipsum" (similarly Gonda, *Indra Hymns* 43): from a grammatical point of view, what is interesting is that in this late hymn, the normal Rig-Vedic *svá-* + genitive pattern (for which we would simply expect *svā́ṃ tanvàm índrasya,* as a way of specifying the new addressee, cf. *tanvàṃ táva svám* 6.11.2d, § **4.2** above) has been substituted with a different - but functionally equivalent - grammatical strategy, namely the appended accusative phrase *índram evá.* One could even hypothesize that in such a late hymn, an original disyllabic scansion of *s(u)vā́m,* in this phrase, which can be paralleled in older hymns (cf. 8.44.12b *tanvàṃ s(u)vā́m*), was actually ousted by the monosyllabic scansion of *svā́m* (which at any rate is far more common for this acc. sg. form), and that this in turn required adjusting an original genitive *índrasya* (in the phrase *s(u)vā́ṃ tanvàm índrasya*) to the pragmatically comparable expression *svā́ṃ tanvàm índram evá.*[16]

16. The long ninth syllable of this hypothetical Triṣṭubh ending with *índrasya* need not be a problem for this scenario: although this metrical feature is rare, it is attested with certainty approximately 100 times (e.g. 7.93.7b *'chā mitráṃ váruṇam índraṃ voceḥ,* cf. Arnold, *Ved. metre* 204); indeed, the relative rarity of the feature might itself have contributed to the ousting of an original *índrasya* in a *svá-* + genitive construction by the otherwise unique (but metrically normal) variant *índram evá* seen here.

4.4 A final point about *svá-* + genitive is more general, and concerns what seems to me an interesting typological parallel within the Rig-Veda. I refer to the demonstration by M. Hale, in his study of intersentential pronominalization in the Taittirīya Saṃhitā,[17] that in the Rig-Veda as well, the deictic pronoun *eṣá-/etá-* refers either to some new element, or to a previously-mentioned referent too far away to be referred to with *sá-/tá-* - i.e., precisely the functional behavior just claimed for the *svá-* + genitive construction.

5. *Nominative svá-*

Before arriving at some tentative conclusions about the semantics and syntax of *svá-*, I must address the other rather striking feature referred to by Renou in (1b) above, namely the use of *svá-* in the nominative case. Although, as Renou observes, this usage is rare (I note some five instances in addition to the one he cites [2.5.7a]),[18] I believe this feature is significant, and deserves to be considered as part of the overall profile of *svá-*. In order to maximize our chances for assessing this usage in terms of its discourse features, it is preferable to consider, instead of the example cited by Renou, a somewhat more extended passage that forms part of a narrative sequence, such as the one in (15):

(15) 8.70.11 *anyávratam ámānuṣam*
áyajvānam ádevayum
áva ***svá́ḥ sákhā*** *dudhuvīta* ***párvataḥ***
sughnáya dásyuṃ párvataḥ
"The one who follows other orders, the 'inhuman' one, the unsacrificing one, the godless one - (him) may his own friend the mountain shake off, (may) the mountain (shake off) Dasyu, to (make him) easy to kill."

In essence, such cases reflect the same relationship with the topic as in the cases discussed above involving "pure" topic control, except that here the possessed element appears as a subject, and not in an oblique case. Thus in (15), the demon described in pādas a and b is clearly topical, although he happens to appear as the grammatical direct object. He is the possessor of "his own friend", the mountain, which is simply the grammatical subject. Subject and topic do not coincide, and the possessor referred to by *svá-* corresponds to the topic.

On the basis of the *svá-* + genitive construction, we could conceptualize this somewhat differently (although the meaning would be the same), as follows: *ányavratam* (etc.) - ***svá́ḥ*** *sákhā* (scil. ***asya***) *dudhuvīta*. We could say, in other words - and this is essentially what Delbrück said in (10) above - that a pronominal genitive like *asya*, as in a *svá-* + genitive construction, is implied; but since the reference is to the immediately preceding topic, such

17. M. Hale, *Pronominaliz.*, esp. 7ff.

18. 1.52.4b, 7.1.6c, 7.23.2c, 7.90.3c, 8.70.11c; cf. Grassmann, *Wörterbuch* s.v. *svá-* (4). The usage is noted also by Elizarenkova (*Gramm.* 248), who again merely describes it as "very rare", citing only Renou's single example.

a pronoun need not be expressed. In (16), in contrast (which is a *real* case of *svá-* + genitive involving *asya*), the genitive pronoun serves a pragmatic purpose:

(16) 7.82.6ab *mahé śulkā́ya váruṇasya nú tviṣá́*
ójo mimāte dhruvám ***asya*** *yát* ***svám***
"For a great price, and for the brilliance of Varuna, they both [i.e. Indra and Varuna] measure their strength, which is his own [i.e. Varuna's] everlasting(ly)"

As discussed above, the genitive (here pronominal) signals a return to a previously-mentioned topic (here Varuna) which has been momentarily displaced by another, in this case the dual reference in the intervening verb *mimāte*.

6. *Conclusions*

It should now be clear from these discussions of the salient features of *svá-* in the Rig-Veda that it is not, strictly speaking, a "reflexive possessive" at all, even though Indo-European **sṵo-* is generally taken to be a possessive adjective based more or less directly on the reflexive pronominal stem **se / *sṵe*.[19] While Watkins is surely correct in asserting (op. cit.) that "the sociolinguistic aspects of the semantics of IE **sṵe* go far beyond the notion of 'own',[20] it seems indisputable that in terms of Rig-Vedic diction, the majority of instances of the possessive adjective *svá-* mean just the sort of thing RENOU and others have attempted to describe by a gloss like 'own', or its French or German equivalents, or - and here the parallelism is very striking - an adjective like Russian *sobstvennyj*. Moreover, such a meaning, which is not strictly reflexive, is the only way of making sense of the fact that certain apparently normal usages of *svá-* not only refer to non-subjects, but even, in the case of *svá-* + genitive, introduce new rhematic material. Nevertheless, one can readily see how such a form can come to acquire a value that is essentially reflexive, in the strict sense of the term: this would be likely to occur precisely when subject and topic happen to coincide, and such a tendency would naturally be strengthened as the various forms of topic control pass out of use and the language develops patterns of coreference more narrowly defined in terms of grammatical subject. It may be helpful, before concluding, to schematize such patterns, as in (17):

(17) a. *svá-* with rhematic element (*svá-* + gen., noun [cf. (9)] or pronoun [cf. (16)])
"Agni grows in the worshipper's own house"
"Agni grows in his [= the worshipper's] own house"
b. *svá-* with thematic element (no genitive, since reference is recoverable)
(i) nom. *svá-* [cf. (15)]:

19. For a traditional account, see Schmidt, *Personalpronomina* 145ff., esp. 154ff. ("Das Possessivpronomen des Reflexivums ... ").

20. On IE **sṵe-dh(e)h$_1$-*, see now Watkins, *Formulaic Sequences* 399f. On **sṵe* and **sṵo-* see also Watkins, *Dragon* 149 and 404n4, with discussion of RV 8.70.11 (=(15) above) at 113 (cf. 184 ff. on 8.70 generally).

"Agni (acc.), the radiant one (acc.), his own offering (nom.) delights"
(ii) "pure" topic [cf. (4)-(5)]:
"Agni (acc.) do thou arouse with praise songs in his own house"
(iii) "reduced relative" type [cf. (2), (7)]:
"We approach you, Agni, (who are) growing in your own house"
(iv) subject and topic coincide [cf. (6)] > "true reflexive":
"Agni grows in his own house"

Thus it is precisely the unmarked type (17b.iv) that would naturally be interpretable in terms of pure reflexive possession per se, and the development of *svá-* in this direction in the Classical language becomes predictable. In the Rig-Veda, however, pure reflexive possession is indicated by other means, if it is overtly marked at all, namely by genitive forms of the personal pronouns, such as *táva* for second person singular (which can be used even with coreferent second-person subject), and even (although relatively rarely) instances of *asya* referring to a coreferent third-person subject.[21] I must reserve for the future a discussion of these other forms of reflexive possessive expressions, not to mention certain problems associated with various compounds formed with first member *sva-* (on which see esp. Schmidt, op. cit. 155f.). For the present, however, I hope to have shown that behind Rig-Vedic *svá-*, which is so often casually described as a "reflexive possessive", lies a pragmatically coherent system of reference that is primarily possessive (with certain well-defined topic and focus behaviors), and only secondarily "reflexive".

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21. Renou (*Gramm. véd.* p. 342) cites 1.113.2b, 1.152.3c (but see Geldner *ad loc.*), 4.17.12c, 5.30.10c; indeed, the last-cited passage uses a phrase (*asya śākaír,* Triṣṭubh-final) that is almost formulaic in this usage (cf. 4.17.11c [*asya śākaí*], 6.19.4b [*asya śākaír*]), and still other instances of "reflexive *asya*" can be found (e.g. 1.33.13a). It is interesting to note that while gen. *táva* not infrequently behaves reflexively (i.e., refers to a coreferent second-person subject, e.g. 1.31.12a,d, 1.53.10a,b, 1.62.12d, 1.80.13a, 2.36.4d, 3.6.5b, 3.9.6d, 4.3.14a, 6.8.7a, 6.17.6a [bis], 6.21.7c, cf. also § 4.2 above), my surveys have so far failed to uncover such reflexive behavior for the enclitic gen./dat. form *te,* despite numerous instances in which a genitive interpretation for *te* is more or less clear, not to mention the greater absolute frequency of *te* as compared with *táva.* (The relative rarity of *máma* renders comparison with enclitic *me* rather more difficult.) This fact, if systematic, recalls the "particle-like" syntactic and prosodic behavior of such enclitic pronouns, as discussed (from a diachronic perspective, in terms of the supposed common origin of such pronouns and particles) by Oranskaja, *Mestoimennye.*

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